Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

♠ Q 3
♥ 4 2
♦ K J 10 9 4
♣ 7 6 5 3

♠ 7 6 5
♥ K Q
♦ 8 7 5 2
♣ Q 10 8 2



♠ J 10 9 8 2
♥ J 9 7 3
♦ A 6
♣ K 9

♠ A K 4
♥ A 10 8 6 5
♦ Q 3
♣ A J 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠J

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠J.

West plays the ♠5 and you the ♠3.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 5

You need 4 more winners, and they will come from the ♦ suit once you have knocked out the ♦A. But there is one danger to avoid - if the defenders don't take the ♦A on the first round dummy won't have a ♦ to lead back to your hand. So to make sure you have an entry back you win the first trick with dummy's ♠K, saving your ♠Q.

You start on ♦s with the ♦Q, then the ♦K. Assume the defenders take their ♦A on the second round.

Win whatever they now play and come to your hand with the ♠Q to enjoy your three established ♦s for 9 tricks total.

Establishing the ♦s is the straightforward way to make the contract.

Just don't foul up on your ♠ entry.

Board 2
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 8 7 6
♥ A J 9 8
♦ 9 4
♣ Q 10 7 3

♠ Q 10 2
♥ 7 3
♦ K 8 7 6 3
♣ 8 5 4



♠ 4
♥ K Q 10 6 5
♦ Q J 10 2
♣ K J 6

♠ A K J 9 5 3
♥ 4 2
♦ A 5
♣ A 9 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♠
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♠6

You were counting on North to have a little better hand than that! South is to play 4♠. West leads the ♠6.

East plays the ♠4 and you win with the ♠A.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=0 ♣=2 Total = 4

You must find a place for one of those losers and that will mean establishing the ♦ suit. If ♦s split 3-3 that will be pretty easy so you should plan to deal with a 4-2 split. Dummy entries are limited so win the first trick in your hand with the ♠A.

Before you pull any trumps you start on the ♦s by playing ♦A, ♦K and then ruffing a ♦ with the ♠K. West follows to the first two, then discards a ♥.

Play a small trump to dummy's ♠10 (East shows out) and ruff another ♦ with the ♠J.

Dummy's last ♦ is now good. Play a ♠ to the ♠Q, (pulling West's last trump), and discard a ♥ or ♣ loser on the ♦8.

You had to establish the ♦s to make 10 tricks. And once again you had to pay close attention to entries.

Board 3
North Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ A K 7 2 ♥ A 8 3 ♦ A Q 7 2 ♣ 6 2	
♠ Q 10 9 6 3 ♥ Q 9 ♦ K 4 ♣ J 9 8 7		♠ J 4 ♥ K 10 5 4 ♦ J 10 9 5 3 ♣ 10 5
	♠ 8 5 ♥ J 7 6 2 ♦ 8 6 ♣ A K Q 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♦J

South's ♣ bid was Stayman, but he didn't match ♠s. North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♦J, West plays the ♦K and you win with the ♦A.

East plays low.

West wins with the ♣7.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 8

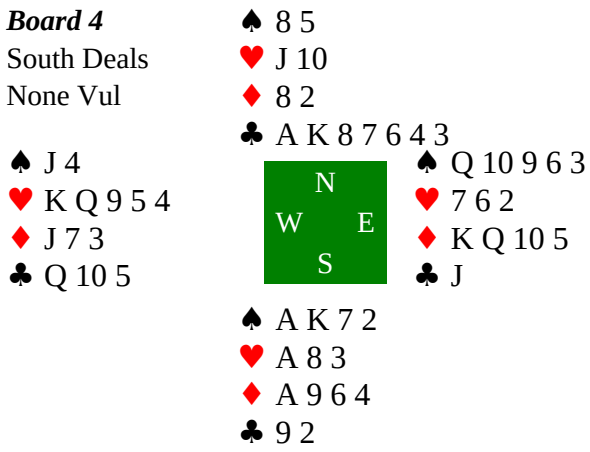
With the ♦K onside you have 8 tricks, and only need one more. If ♣s split 3-3 you can get 2 extras and make an overtrick. But when you are missing 6 cards they are more likely to be 4-2 than 3-3. Since you only need 4 ♣ tricks you should establish the suit with a duck.

Win the ♦A and play a small ♣ from each hand.

The defense gets a cheap trick in ♣s but you don't mind because you still have a small ♣ for an entry to dummy. You win whatever they return and take the rest of your winners, including 4 tricks in ♣s!

If you had played the ♣s from the top you would have come up one trick short.

Board 4
South Deals
None Vul



West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥5

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥5, dummy plays the ♥10, East the ♥2 and you the ♥3. Dummy wins.

East wins with the ♣J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 7

You are very lucky. Apparently West led from ♥ K Q so you won an undeserved ♥ trick. Now, if ♣s split 2-2 you can make 12 tricks! But hold it a minute. If you play dummy's two top ♣s and they **DON'T** split 2-2 you will only win two ♣ tricks and the contract will fail. Instead you should play a small ♣ from dummy right now. The defenders will win the trick easily, but you will win their return and you will still have a ♣ to get to dummy's 6 ♣ winners!

Ducking a ♣ is the only way to make the contract and you might as well do it at the second trick.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A K 5 ♥ A K 6 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A K 4 2	
♠ J 8 3 ♥ J 10 8 5 ♦ K J ♣ Q 9 8 3	N W E S	♠ Q 10 7 2 ♥ Q 9 4 ♦ Q 10 9 ♣ J 10 7
	♠ 9 6 4 ♥ 7 3 2 ♦ A 8 5 4 2 ♣ 6 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠2

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠2, dummy plays the ♠4 and West the ♠J.

East plays low.

West wins with the ♦J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need two more winners and dummy's ♦suit is your only hope. **IF** ♦s split 3-2 and **IF** the defenders don't take too many winners in their suit(s) you can establish ♦s by ducking twice.

Win the first ♠. If you hold up they might pocket the ♠ trick and switch to another suit where you only have two stoppers.

Next play a small ♦ from each hand. Win the return (probably a ♠) and duck a second ♦.

If the defenders can only take 2 ♠ tricks now you are home-free since dummy's 3 ♦s are now established.

You had to have the defender's ♠s split 4-3. But in fact you were pretty sure they were going to do so. Since East's ♠2 was probably his fourth-down then he couldn't have a fifth-down.

Board 6
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 7 4 ♥ K 10 9 8 3 ♦ J 5 3 ♣ Q 3	
♠ Q 10 5 2 ♥ 7 4 2 ♦ 8 7 ♣ J 8 7 2		♠ J 9 8 ♥ A 6 5 ♦ Q 10 9 6 ♣ K 9 5
	♠ K 6 3 ♥ Q J ♦ A K 4 2 ♣ A 10 6 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♥
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠2

North's 3♦ bid was a transfer to ♥s. South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠2.

East plays the ♠J and you win with the ♠K.

West plays low.

East plays low too.

West plays low.

East holds up his ♥A again.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 5

Obviously you need to establish 4 ♥ winners and by driving out the ♥A you can manage that handily. The problem is that dummy has only one sure entry, (the ♠A), and the defenders may be good enough to hold up their ♥A twice.

To assure the contract you should win the first trick in your hand with the ♠K. Then play ♥Q, ♥J overtaking with dummy's ♥K so you can continue establishing the suit while you still have that ♠ entry.

None of the other suits were sitting well so overtaking the ♥ was the way to go.

Board 7
South Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K Q 9 8 7 5 2 ♥ A 2 ♦ A 2 ♣ 5 2	
♠ — ♥ 10 9 6 3 ♦ K Q J 9 4 ♣ Q 10 9 7		♠ 10 3 ♥ K Q J 8 4 ♦ 10 8 7 5 ♣ J 8
	♠ A J 6 4 ♥ 7 5 ♦ 6 3 ♣ A K 6 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	1♠	Pass	2♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by North
Lead: ♥K

North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥5 and West the ♥3.

You win the ♥A and draw trumps with the ♠K and ♠Q.

East plays low.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 2

One of the two red losers must be discarded on dummy's ♣ suit. So you pull trumps, taking two rounds, with ♠K and ♠Q. Then play two top ♣s and ruff a ♣. When East shows out on the third ♣, enter dummy with a trump and ruff another ♣. Dummy's final ♣ is now established, so enter dummy with another trump and discard one of the red losers on the fifth ♣.

As long as the ♣s were no worse than 4-2 you can establish the suit.

Board 8
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 10 9 7 2 ♥ A J 6 ♦ 7 5 ♣ Q 6 4 3	
♠ K 6 4 3 ♥ 9 7 ♦ K 10 8 6 2 ♣ 8 2	N W E S	♠ A 8 ♥ Q 10 8 2 ♦ Q J 9 ♣ J 10 9 7
	♠ Q J 5 ♥ K 5 4 3 ♦ A 4 3 ♣ A K 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
All Pass			

1NT by South
Lead: ♦6

South is to play 1NT. West leads the ♦6, taken by East with the ♦J. East next plays the ♦Q on which West plays the ♦2. East plays the ♦9 which you finally win.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 6

You only need one more winner and you have several possibilities. The ♥ finesse might work, or the ♣s might split 3-3. But you need to consider the defenders winners also. They have already scored 2 ♦ tricks and will get 2 more as soon as they gain the lead. (The spot cards told you that West has a 5-card ♦ suit.) Plus they have the 2 top ♠s which they can take whenever they like. So if your play sets up just one more trick for them you will go down.

No, you must establish ♠s, the suit where they have 2 winners anyway. So you play a ♠ which West wins. He takes his 2 ♦s but you are now home free. When you gain the lead again you will get your ♠ winner established and only lose 2 ♠s and 4 ♦s.

If you finessed the ♥ you would have gone down with the defenders winning 4 ♦s, 1 ♥ and 2 ♠s.

If you had played 3 rounds of ♣s you would have gone down with the defenders winning 4 ♦s, 1 ♣ and 2 ♠s.

Only by establishing ♠s can you make the contract.

Board 9
North Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K J 7 ♥ A K 7 5 ♦ A 8 7 3 ♣ K Q	
♠ A 4 ♥ J 10 4 ♦ Q J 10 6 ♣ J 7 5 4	N W E S	♠ 9 8 6 5 3 ♥ Q 9 3 2 ♦ K 4 ♣ 6 2
	♠ Q 10 2 ♥ 8 6 ♦ 9 5 2 ♣ A 10 9 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠9

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠9, taken by West with the ♠A. West next plays the ♠4.

You win with the ♠K and East plays low.

Everyone follows low.

East plays low.

West follows with the ♣5.

West wins with the ♣J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 8

You only need one more winner and if ♦s split 3-3 you can easily establish a trick in that suit. But what if ♦s split 4-2? If the ♣J falls you can get an extra ♣ trick. In fact, no matter how the ♣s are arranged you can establish your extra trick there.

First make sure that you win the second trick with the ♠K, keeping dummy's ♠Q for a later entry. Then play ♣K, and ♣Q overtaking with dummy's ♣A. Then play the ♣10, losing to the ♣J but establishing the ♣9 while you still have the ♠Q as an entry.

As you see, you couldn't set up a ♦ trick so the ♣ overtake was necessary to make the contract.

Board 10
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 8 5 2 ♥ Q 7 ♦ K 7 4 ♣ 8 6 4 3	
♠ Q 10 4 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ 9 3 2 ♣ K Q J 10	N W E S	♠ K J 9 ♥ J 10 8 4 ♦ Q J 10 5 ♣ 9 2
	♠ 7 6 3 ♥ A K 5 2 ♦ A 8 6 ♣ A 7 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	2NT		
All Pass			

2NT by South
Lead: ♣K

South is to play 2NT. West leads the ♣K, dummy plays the ♣3 and East the ♣2.

West plays low.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=3 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 7

You need to find another winner and the chances are not good. If either black suit splits 3-3 you can establish dummy's fourth card in that suit. But with West's opening lead of the ♣K it is unlikely that ♣s will split. So your only slim hope is that the ♠s split 3-3 and dummy's fourth ♠ will be a winner.

Win the first trick and play a ♠ to the ♠A. Then play another ♠. The defense will win and probably take some ♣ tricks . When they have finished and play a red card, you win it and play a third round of ♠s. If both defenders follow to all three ♠s then dummy's ♠8 is now a winner.

This time you were lucky and the ♠s split evenly. Next time they probably won't and you'll go down.

Board 11
North Deals
None Vul

♠ Q
♥ Q 10 9 7 6
♦ A J 3
♣ A 7 4 2

♠ A K 9 7
♥ 4 2
♦ K 10 8 4
♣ 9 6 5



♠ J 10 4
♥ 8 3
♦ Q 9 7 2
♣ K Q J 10

♠ 8 6 5 3 2
♥ A K J 5
♦ 6 5
♣ 8 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♣K

North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♣K, dummy plays the ♣3 and West the ♣5.

West wins the ♠K.

West plays a trump, you follow low and East too.

Dummy leads a ♠ and West plays low.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 6

Obviously you don't really have 6 losers since some of those ♦s and ♣s can be ruffed in dummy. But if you are playing against competent defenders you will only be able to ruff two of them because every time they get the lead they will play a trump. So you must figure on ruffing 2 losers and establishing dummy's fifth ♠ for a discard of the other one.

Win the ♣A and immediately play your ♠Q. The defense will win this trick and probably play a trump. Be sure to win this in dummy and then ruff a ♠ with a high ♥. Now exit with a ♣. They will win and probably play another trump. Win this one in dummy also, breathing a sigh of relief when ♥s split 2-2. Ruff another ♠ with your second-last trump, then play ♦A and concede a ♦.

Whichever minor suit the defense plays next you ruff in dummy, then ruff the fourth ♠, establishing dummy's ♠8 while you still have a trump left in dummy. Dummy is now high.

It took a 2-2 trump split and a 4-3 ♠ split. But that was your best shot.

Board 12
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 7 5 ♥ K 8 7 5 3 ♦ A K 5 ♣ 10 2	
♠ J 9 6 3 ♥ J 2 ♦ Q J 10 7 6 ♣ 8 4	N W E S	♠ Q 10 4 ♥ Q 10 9 6 ♦ 9 3 2 ♣ 7 6 3
	♠ A K 2 ♥ A 4 ♦ 8 4 ♣ A K Q J 9 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♣
Pass	2♥	Pass	3♣
Pass	3NT	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♦[2]	Pass	5NT[3]
Pass	6♥[4]	Pass	7♣
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace
3. asks for kings
4. 2 kings

7♣ by South
Lead: ♦Q

South is to play 7♣. West leads the ♦Q.

East plays the ♦2 and you the ♦4.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=0 ♣=0 Total = 1

It should be very clear that the only way to get rid of that ♠ loser is to discard it on dummy's ♥ suit. So after taking the first trick with dummy's ♦A you could pull trumps, then play ♥A, ♥K and ruff a ♥. **IF** the ♥s split 3-3 you could then enter dummy with the ♦K and discard your loser.

The problem is that the ♥s are much more likely to split 4-2, in which case you will need to ruff twice to establish a winner. That means you will need an extra entry to dummy.

That extra entry can only be the ♣10 so you must delay pulling trumps until after you ruff the first ♥. Win the ♦A and immediately play ♥A, ♥K and ruff a ♥ with a high ♣. West discards on this ♥ play. Enter dummy with a trump and ruff another ♥ high. The suit is now established, so you pull trumps, enter dummy one last time with the ♦K and discard that losing ♠ on the good ♥8.

It may have seemed too risky to play ♥s before pulling trumps. In fact, there was no risk at all. If the ♥s were splitting 5-1 then you had absolutely no chance of making the contract.

And if they had split 3-3 this Plan would still have worked.

Board 13
South Deals
Both Vul

	♠ A K 5 2 ♥ A K 4 3 ♦ 7 5 3 ♣ 9 5	
♠ J 9 7 ♥ Q 10 9 6 ♦ J 9 ♣ J 10 6 2	N W E S	♠ Q 10 6 4 ♥ J 8 2 ♦ K 8 4 ♣ Q 8 3
	♠ 8 3 ♥ 7 5 ♦ A Q 10 6 2 ♣ A K 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♦
Pass	1♥	Pass	2♣
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠4

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠4, dummy plays the ♠3 and West the ♠J.

East plays low.

West wins with the ♦J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need two more winners. They cannot possibly come from ♠s, ♥s, or ♣s since one defender must hold at least 4 cards in each of those suits. So your two extra winners must come from the ♦ suit.

There is no reason to hold up on the ♠ since the ♥ and ♣ suits also have just two stoppers. You win the ♠A.

You best play next is to finesse the ♦10. This may gain a trick by virtue of the finesse if East happens to hold the ♦J, but primarily you are working to establish the ♦ suit. Assume West wins the ♦J and returns a ♠.

Again don't hold up. Take the ♠K and lead another small ♦, finessing with dummy's ♦Q. Happily this time the finesse works, and even more happily both defenders follow suit. That means the rest of the ♦s are good and you make an overtrick.

This was just a normal suit-establishment Deal.

If looked different because of the two finesses you took.

Board 14
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ 9 7 ♥ 4 3 ♦ 8 6 5 2 ♣ A 8 6 5 3	
♠ J 10 6 4 2 ♥ K J 8 ♦ 10 7 3 ♣ K 2		♠ A 8 5 ♥ Q 10 9 6 ♦ Q J 9 ♣ 10 7 4
	♠ K Q 3 ♥ A 7 5 2 ♦ A K 4 ♣ Q J 9	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	Pass	Pass	1♣
Pass	2♣	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠4

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠4. East puts on the ♠A and returns the ♠8.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 6

Needing three more winners you are going to have to establish the ♣ suit. You are also going to have to be lucky!

You win the second ♠ and play your ♣Q. West covers with the ♣K. What do you do next?

You **DUCK**. If you take the ♣A now you will never get back to dummy to enjoy those other ♣s. So let West have the ♣K. You win his return, (probably a ♠), and play ♣J, then ♣9 to dummy's ♣A. As long as ♣s split 3-2 you will get the three winners you need.

You were prepared to lose that ♣ finesse to East so you could establish the suit in dummy.

West's play of the ♣K may have made you want to jump up with the ♣A, but you must stick to the original play of ducking one trick.

Board 15
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A Q 3 ♥ 6 3 ♦ A K 5 4 ♣ A Q 6 5	
♠ J 9 6 ♥ J 9 2 ♦ Q J 10 ♣ 10 9 3 2	N W E S	♠ K 10 8 2 ♥ K 10 4 ♦ 8 7 2 ♣ K J 7
	♠ 7 5 4 ♥ A Q 8 7 5 ♦ 9 6 3 ♣ 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
Pass	1♦	Pass	1♥
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠2

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠2, dummy plays the ♠4 and West puts on the ♠J.

East plays low.

West wins with the ♥9.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 6

You need three more winners. It is possible your fourth ♦ can be established, but that needs a 3-3 split. It's also possible that the ♣ finesse will work, and also the ♥ finesse. Since you need the ♥ finesse anyway you should go ahead and try to establish the ♥s.

Win the first trick with your ♠Q and play a low ♥, ducking in dummy. West will no doubt win a cheap trick but no matter. When you next gain the lead play your other low ♥ and finesse the ♥Q. Assume this wins (if it doesn't you will be going down for sure). Play the ♥A and if both defenders follow your other 2 ♥s are good and your contract is made.

Ducking the first ♥ and finessing the second could let you wind up with no tricks at all in the ♥ suit.

But, it is your only chance to make the contract.

Board 16
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 6 5 3 ♥ K 5 4 ♦ K J 10 8 5 ♣ Q	
♠ K Q J 10 ♥ 10 9 ♦ 7 4 3 ♣ K 10 7 2		♠ A 9 2 ♥ J 7 3 ♦ A 9 2 ♣ J 9 6 5
	♠ 7 4 ♥ A Q 8 6 2 ♦ Q 6 ♣ A 8 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	3♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♠K

Some pretty agressive bidding gets you to a challenging game. South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♠K, overtaken by East's ♠A. East returns a ♠ to West's ♠10, and he then plays the ♠Q.

You ruff the third ♠.

West plays low.

East ducks.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 6

With 2 tricks already gone you still have 4 losers. You could consider ruffing the 3 ♣ losers in dummy but that would just create a trump loser even when trumps are splitting 3-2. So it looks like you will have to establish the ♦ suit for discards. You could pull trumps and then play your ♦Q, hoping the defenders will grab their ♦A immediately. But unless they are real novices they will hold it up one round and you'll no longer be able to reach dummy.

The solution is to establish the ♦s before you use up dummy's ♥K.

Ruff the third ♠, then play ♦Q, (which they will duck), and another ♦, (which they will probably take). Win whatever they return, pull trumps ending in dummy, and enjoy your 3 ♦ winners.

If East does not take the second ♦ you continue the suit, and whether you ruff or discard a loser you still make the contract.

Board 17
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 7 5 ♥ J 7 ♦ A 10 8 6 3 ♣ A K 5	
♠ 4 3 2 ♥ A 8 2 ♦ K J 5 ♣ Q 10 7 4	N W E S	♠ K 10 8 6 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ Q 7 2 ♣ J 9 2
	♠ Q J 9 ♥ K Q 10 5 4 ♦ 9 4 ♣ 8 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠6

South's 3♦ bid was a transfer to ♥s, and his 2NT bid showed exactly 5 ♥s with an invitational strength hand. North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠6, you play dummy's ♠9 and West contributes the ♠2.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 5

The math is easy - you need 4 ♥ tricks. And you should be able to manage that by driving out the ♥A. But the defenders will probably hold up one or two rounds when you play on ♥s, so you must have an outside entry to dummy.

The ♠ Q J will provide that entry **IF** you make sure to win the first trick with your ♠A as an unblocking move. If you don't do so then East will be able to keep you out of the dummy and away from those good ♥s.

Suppose you allow dummy's ♠9 to hold the first trick, then start on ♥s. West will hold up the ♥A for 1 or 2 rounds. When he does win it he will return a ♠ and whether you play the ♠A or a low ♠ East will be able to prevent you from reaching dummy.

But if you win the first trick with the ♠A, then dummy's ♠ Q J will provide a guaranteed entry to the good ♥s.

Board 18
West Deals
None Vul

	♠ K J 4 ♥ Q J 10 5 3 ♦ 7 5 4 ♣ 8 2	
♠ Q 9 7 2 ♥ K 6 4 ♦ 10 8 2 ♣ Q 6 3		♠ 8 6 3 ♥ A 8 2 ♦ Q J 9 ♣ J 10 7 4
	♠ A 10 5 ♥ 9 7 ♦ A K 6 3 ♣ A K 9 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	Pass	Pass	1♦
Pass	1♥	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠2

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠2, you play dummy's ♠4 and East plays the ♠8.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=2 Total = 7

Needing just two more winners it looks straightforward to establish dummy's ♥ suit. Suppose you win the ♠10 and play the ♥9. If the defenders win this trick you are home free. You win their ♠ return with your ♠A, then continue ♥s to drive out their last stopper while you still have the ♠K as a dummy entry.

This won't work against good defenders, who will hold up on the first ♥ trick and win the second. Then when they continue ♠s you won't have another ♥ to return to dummy, so while you can use the ♠K as an entry to establish the ♥s you will never get back to use the good ones.

Instead you should win the first trick with your ♠A. Now when you attack ♥s a defensive holdup won't hurt you because you have **TWO** ♠ entries, the ♠J by a finesse and the ♠K.

West is almost certain to hold the ♠Q because his ♠2 opening lead promises an honor and the ♠Q is the only one you don't have.

So the ♠ finesse is an odds-on play to get a second dummy entry.

Board 19
West Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ — ♥ K 8 4 ♦ A K J 7 6 5 2 ♣ A 6 5	
♠ A K 7 5 4 3 ♥ J 9 5 ♦ — ♣ J 10 7 2		♠ 10 9 6 ♥ Q 10 7 2 ♦ 9 4 3 ♣ K Q 8
	♠ Q J 8 2 ♥ A 6 3 ♦ Q 10 8 ♣ 9 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2♠	Dbl	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♦	Pass	4♦
Pass	5♦		
All Pass			

5♦ by North
Lead: ♠10

3NT would have been a lot easier, but you didn't get there. North is to play 5♦. East leads the ♠10.

West plays the ♠K and you ruff with the ♦2.

East plays low.

West shows out.

West covers with the ♠A.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=2 Total = 3

The good news is that you only have one loser to get rid of. The bad news is that there doesn't seem to be a good place to put it.

Unlikely as it seems, your best candidate for establishment is dummy's ♠8. East is marked with 3 ♠s, and having led the ♠10 there is a good chance that he also has the ♠9. If so you can ruff it out.

Cover the ♠10 with dummy's ♠J, and when West plays one of his honors ruff in your hand. Play a trump to the ♦10, West showing out. Lead the ♠Q. West will be forced to play his other high honor, (if he doesn't you would discard a loser), and you ruff again.

Back to dummy with the ♦Q and ruff the ♠2 with a high trump just to be safe. East drops the ♠9 on this trick.

Pull East's last trump and enter dummy with the ♥A and **FINALLY** discard a loser on the now established ♠8.

When your only hope of making a contract is for the defender's cards to be a certain way, just assume that they lie perfectly for you and barge ahead.

Here you needed ♠ 10 9 x to be with East if you were to make the contract so you played for just that holding.

Board 20
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 6 4 ♥ A 9 3 ♦ 8 6 ♣ 9 8 6 4 3	
♠ 5 3 ♥ J 7 6 4 ♦ K J 7 3 2 ♣ 10 5	N W E S	♠ 8 2 ♥ Q 8 2 ♦ Q 10 9 4 ♣ Q J 7 2
	♠ A Q J 10 9 7 ♥ K 10 5 ♦ A 5 ♣ A K	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	Pass	Pass	2♣
Pass	2NT	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♦[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♠ by South
Lead: ♠5

South is to play 6♠. West leads the ♠5.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 2

First pull trumps with the ♠A and ♠Q, both defenders following. Next you must establish dummy's ♣ suit to get rid of one of your losers. If the suit splits 3-3 that will be easy since you have two dummy entries, one to get there to ruff the third ♣ and the other to get there to enjoy playing the winners. But ♣s will probably split 4-2 so the two entries won't be enough. Here's how to make the defenders help you establish the suit.

After pulling trumps, play the ♣ A K, then ♦A.

You exit with a small ♦ and East wins.

The defender who won the ♦ trick has a problem. If he plays another ♦ you will get a ruff-sluff, and if he plays a ♥ you will play for the ♥Q and ♥J to be in different hands. So he will probably play a ♣.

You ruff in your hand, play a trump to dummy's ♠K and ruff the ♣8, establishing the ♣9 while you still have the ♥ entry.

Notice that this Plan would also succeed if the ♣s had split 3-3.

This was a combination of Suit Establishment and End-play. The lesson on Eliminations contains a lot more of this type of hand.